

Let's pull in the text of *Alice in Wonderland* and try to count the number of words in the text. To do this, we'll use the string method `split()`, which by default splits a string wherever it finds any whitespace:

```
from pathlib import Path

path = Path('alice.txt')
try:
    contents = path.read_text(encoding='utf-8')
except FileNotFoundError:
    print(f"Sorry, the file {path} does not exist.")
else:
    # Count the approximate number of words in the file:
    ❶ words = contents.split()
    ❷ num_words = len(words)
    print(f"The file {path} has about {num_words} words.")
```

I moved the file *alice.txt* to the correct directory, so the try block will work this time. We take the string contents, which now contains the entire text of *Alice in Wonderland* as one long string, and use `split()` to produce a list of all the words in the book ❶. Using `len()` on this list ❷ gives us a good approximation of the number of words in the original text. Lastly, we print a statement that reports how many words were found in the file. This code is placed in the else block because it only works if the code in the try block was executed successfully.

The output tells us how many words are in *alice.txt*:

The file *alice.txt* has about 29594 words.

The count is a little high because extra information is provided by the publisher in the text file used here, but it's a good approximation of the length of *Alice in Wonderland*.

Working with Multiple Files

Let's add more books to analyze, but before we do, let's move the bulk of this program to a function called `count_words()`. This will make it easier to run the analysis for multiple books:

```
word_count.py from pathlib import Path

def count_words(path):
    ❶ """Count the approximate number of words in a file."""
    try:
        contents = path.read_text(encoding='utf-8')
    except FileNotFoundError:
        print(f"Sorry, the file {path} does not exist.")
    else:
        # Count the approximate number of words in the file:
        words = contents.split()
        num_words = len(words)
        print(f"The file {path} has about {num_words} words.")
```